

37 Past possibility

You can use a variety of language to talk about possible events in the past, and to indicate whether you agree or disagree with speculation.

⚙️ **New language** "Might / may / could" in the past

Aa **Vocabulary** Urban myths

🧩 **New skill** Talking about past possibility

37.1 KEY LANGUAGE PAST POSSIBILITY

You can use this construction to talk about something that you think possibly happened in the past.



The copier isn't working. It $\left\{ \begin{array}{c} \text{might} \\ \text{may} \\ \text{could} \end{array} \right\}$ have run out of paper.

[He thinks it is possible that the copier has run out of paper.]

You can use this construction to talk about something that possibly did not happen in the past.



You $\left\{ \begin{array}{c} \text{might not} \\ \text{may not} \end{array} \right\}$ have plugged it in properly.

[He thinks it is possible that the printer wasn't plugged in properly.]

"Could not" can only be used when the speaker is certain that something did not happen.



You couldn't have changed the ink properly earlier.

[He is certain that the ink wasn't changed properly.]

